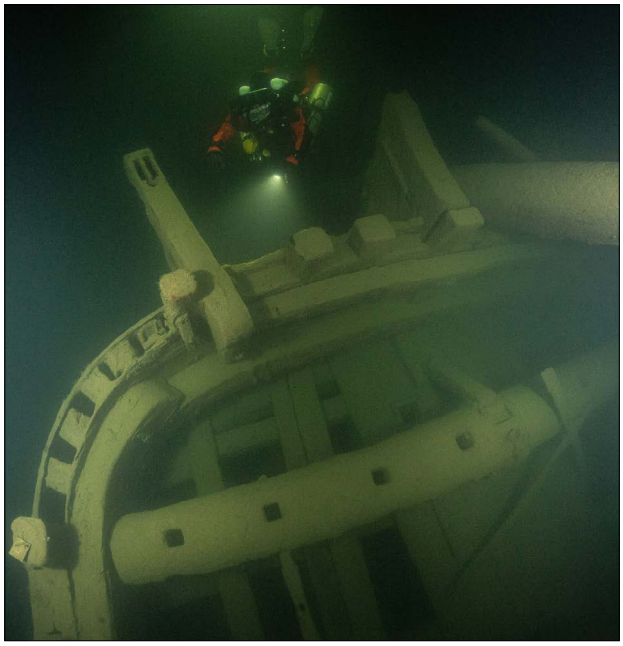

Figure 31: The bow of the wreck of the Vrouw Maria seen from above. (Jouni Polkko, Badewanne team 2019).

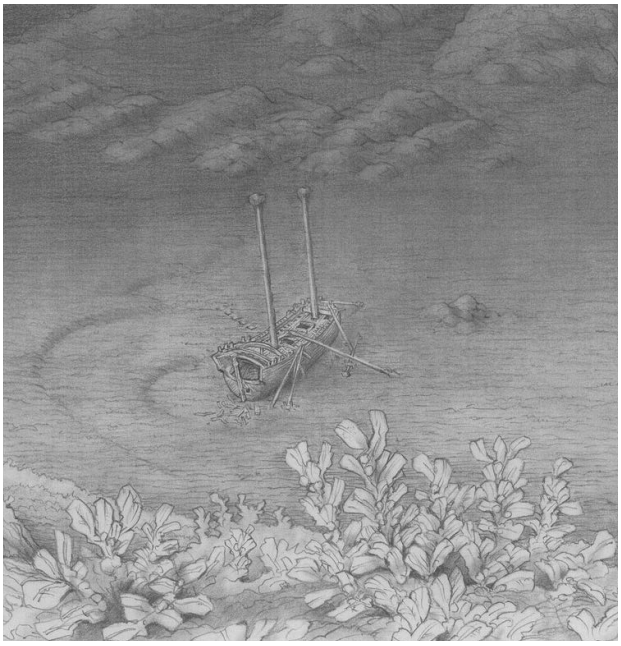

Figure 32: An artist's view of the wreck of the Vrouw Maria in its underwater environment at the depth of 41 metres. Underwater rocks are shown behind the wreck and underwater vegetation in front of the wreck. (Tiina Miettinen, Finnish Heritage Agency).

The wreck of the Vrouw Maria was reassessed as part of the Nationally Significant Archaeological Sites in Finland project (VARK) in 2022 (see section 6.3).

Description of site

The hull of the wreck is approximately 26m long and 7m wide. The masts rise to a depth of 22–24 m. Parts of the structure and the rig lie on the seabed around the wreck (Figs.31 & 32).

The Vrouw Maria was a Dutch merchant ship on her way to St Petersburg from Amsterdam. The Vrouw Maria is one of the few wreck sites in the Gulf of Finland that has been identified with certainty based on archival sources. She started her last voyage in early September 1771 and passed the Danish custom station in Sound on 23 September. According to the Sound customs register her cargo included zinc, dyestuff, sugar, coffee beans, cloth, mercury, cheese, butter and some valuable pieces of art and silver. Some of the art was bought for the Russian Empress Catherine the Great. The ship got lost in the Gulf of Finland and ran aground. The ship did not sink immediately, and the crew tried to save her and her cargo for several days. Some silver and pieces of art were salvaged, but most of the cargo was lost when the ship finally sank. After her loss there were attempts to find her for salvaging the lost goods. The attempts failed and the ship was forgotten for more than 200 years.

The Vrouw Maria's story was known from archive sources since the 1970s and several divers tried to locate the wreck without succeeding. An association called Pro Vrouw Maria managed to locate the wreck in 1999 by using side scan sonar. The wreck was investigated in 2001-2004 as part of the international MoSS project (Monitoring, Safeguarding and Visualizing North-European Shipwreck Sites). The other active research period took place in 2010-2012 during the Finnish Heritage Agency project "Vrouw Maria under Water".

Assessing significance – methods

According to the Finnish Antiquities Act, a wreck is automatically protected by the act, if the wreck can be supposed to have sunk more than a hundred years ago. The cultural-historical significance of wrecks does not need to be defined separately in more detail. When deciding on the use of limited resources, however, prioritization must be done, so it is about choosing what to study. For prioritization, the cultural-historical significance of a site should be defined based on the agreed criteria.

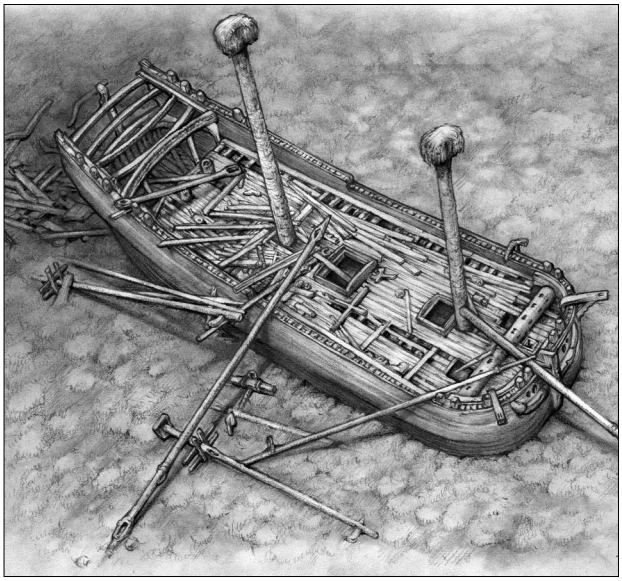

Figure 33: An artist's view of the wreck of the Vrouw Maria based on photos of the wreck. (Tiina Miettinen, Finnish Heritage Agency 2004).

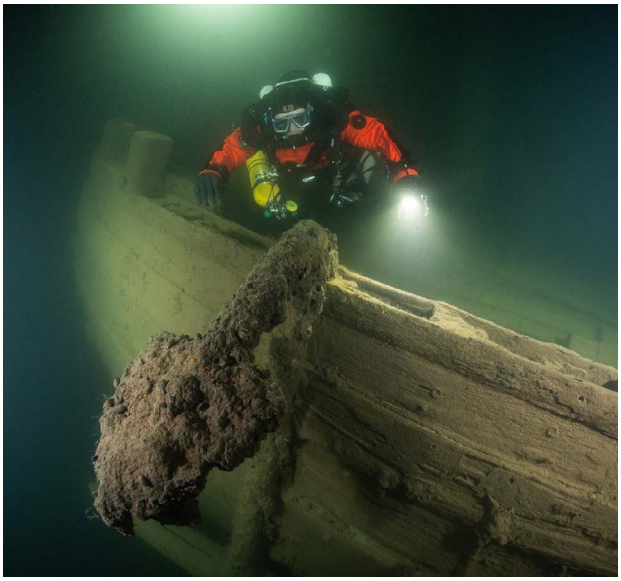

Figure 34: Anchor on the port side of the wreck near the bow. (Jouni Polkko, Badewanne team 2019).

Definition is a mechanism by which the significance of an object is evaluated and described based on selected criteria. Finally, a summary is made of the described values. The definition also includes a comparison of the object with other similar objects at the local, regional, national and international levels. It is a difficult task to develop generally acceptable evaluation criteria suitable for the mutual comparison of ancient remains. Using these criteria is also tricky. The evaluations are never final, but always relative, because they only discuss the current situation. New targets may change the ranking order.

At the time the Vrouw Maria was found in 1999, the Finnish Heritage Agency did not have a broader evaluation method for determining the significance of archaeological sites and objects. The only officially used evaluation system was a three-level classification, where objects were classified into categories 1–3. In this system the Vrouw Maria was classified as a first-class archaeological site, which meant that the wreck was nationally significant, and its preservation must be secured under all circumstances. To determine the significance of the Vrouw Maria in more detail, a new system was created. In creating this new system and suitable criteria, the following existing systems were used as examples where applicable: the criteria developed under the international maritime archaeological MoSS Project (2001-2004), the ICOMOS Australia's Burra Charter criteria (ICOMOS Australia, 2013), and the Advisory Committee on Historic Wreck Sites criteria. On the basis of these three systems, the aesthetic and experiential value and condition of the site, the ship type of the wreck and the shipbuilding historical value, the typicality of the ship type of the wreck and/or the rarity, volume and variation of the wreck's material, as well as the historical value of the wreck were determined. The Vrouw Maria was evaluated on the basis of the selected criteria in collaboration with many experts, then described in full and in a shorter summary.

The evaluation process shows that in the cultural-historical sense the wreck of the Vrouw Maria is of great significance both nationally and internationally. The wreck is exceptionally well preserved; approximately 90% of the hull is preserved as well as the rigging. The Vrouw Maria represents a typical snow rigged merchant vessel of its time, the end of the 18th century. These ships sailed the Baltic Sea with a cargo of miscellaneous goods. There is only one other snow rigged ship known from the end of the 18th century that is as well preserved as the Vrouw Maria. That ship, the Sjöhästen, located in Swedish territorial waters, was a war ship and thus differs from the Vrouw Maria. What makes the cultural-historical importance of the Vrouw Maria even greater is the volume and variation of the wreck's findings, the possible art treasures that were on their way to Catherine II of Russia, and the number of archive materials and historical persons connected with the ship.

The assessment

When the wreck of the Vrouw Maria was reassessed in 2022 during the VARK project, the following criteria were used and the significance of the wreck was described in the following way:

Cultural-historic significance

The ship is a merchant vessel commonly used in 18th-century traffic in the Baltic Sea. The wreck is a concrete manifestation of an important sea route and trade between Russia and Western Europe.

Score: 3 = significant potential.

Research value

Since its discovery in 1999, the wreck has been studied mainly with non-destructive methods. Only a few objects have been lifted and no large-scale excavations have been carried out. The wreck has a lot of research potential both in terms of shipbuilding and cultural-historical artefacts. It is known that the ship's cargo contained, e.g., works of art and art objects purchased for the Empress of Russia.

Score: 3 = significant potential.

Prevalence or rarity

There are approximately 70 wrecks or wreck parts in the Finnish Heritage Agency register of ancient sites and monuments, which are assumed or known to date from the 18th century. Only a minority of them have a well-preserved hull and contain plenty of cargo and objects.

Score: 3 = very rare or common.

Archaeological diversity

The wreck is located in the outer archipelago area, where three other historic shipwrecks are known to exist within a 5 km radius of small islets.

Score: 2 = diverse.

Environment and landscape

The wreck is located in the outer archipelago, in an area whose environment and underwater landscape has not been changed by construction projects. The location is in the Archipelago National Park and nature reserve. The hull rests in a small depression surrounded by rocky islets, where the depth is about 41 m.

Score: 2 = there are features in the environment and the landscape making it easier to understand the site.

Degree of preservation

The hull is well preserved and most of the cargo remains in the ship's hold. Only a part of the cargo could be saved after running aground. The lower parts of the masts are upright (Figs.32 & 33).

Score: 3 = well preserved.

Overall, the Vrouw Maria received 15 points out of 18 in the assessment. The wreck was nominated for the list of nationally significant archaeological sites as a well-preserved wreck of a merchant ship related to 18th century international trade shipping in the Baltic Sea, with great research potential.